Pro-government Militias, Plausible Deniability and Public Opinion: Testing the Microfoundations

Devin P. Brown

June 3, 2026

Abstract

Existing research on political violence has asserted that states use pro-government militias for plausible deniability. Leaders, fearful of international punishment but intent on brutalizing their opponents, delegate unsavory violence to sub-state militias to obfuscate the government's involvement and avoid accountability. Yet, we have little direct evidence as to whether government delegation increases the plausibility of denials. Do observers assign less blame to governments that delegate violence to militias instead of the military? Does delegation make denials of involvement more plausible? Does delegating violence lead observers to express more support (oppose punishments) for that government?

Using a survey experiment, I examine how varying degrees of separation between the militia and government affects attributions of blame and how delegation conditions the effect of government denials.

The results support the core expectations of plausible deniability, while clarifying how delegation influences reasoning about government responsibility. As an accountability avoidance strategy, denying involvement appears marginally persuasive and generally insufficient as a response to violence. Given the growing specter of organized political violence in polities across the West, these findings highlight the need for additional work on violence delegation and accountability for abusive leaders.

1 Introduction

Understanding why and when states use pro-government militias (PGMs) has been a critically important question in conflict research. Militias such as the Arkan Tigers, the Interhamwe, and the Janjaweed have been key drivers of genocidal violence in Bosnia, Rwanda, and Sudan respectively. Existing research has shown that PGM presence is associated with increased civilian deaths (Stanton 2015), widespread human rights abuses (Mitchell, Carey, and Butler 2014), and strategic mass killings (Koren 2017). Given PGMs' violent reputation, one of the primary explanations for why states collaborate with militias is to commit egregious violence while insulating the leader from accountability. In theory, the institutional independence of the militia helps the state deny involvement in the violence and appeal to agency slack, shifting blame for violence to the militia itself. In short, militias provide states plausible deniability (Carey, Colaresi, and Mitchell 2015).

Despite the intuitive appeal of this explanation, the empirical record for plausible deniability is mixed. On the one hand, leaders might avoid international convictions for atrocities committed by militias. In Cote d'Ivoire, the president, Laurent Gbagbo, escaped conviction in the International Criminal Court (ICC) for egregious violence committed by militias (BBC 2021). However, legal conviction is just one form of punishment facing abusive leaders. Despite his acquittal, Gbagbo faced sanctions and forcible removal from power by international actors for his militias' abuses (NPR 2011). Whereas delegating violence helped Gbagbo avoid legal conviction, it did not completely save him from accountability. More broadly, the extent to which delegation makes denials more plausible or shields leaders from punishment remains unclear.

In this paper, I test how observers (mis-)assign blame for delegated political violence. Do leaders that delegate violence to militias actually receive less blame than those that use the military? Does this delegation make the leader's denial of involvement more plausible? Does using militias render international observers more willing to support (less willing to punish) the government?

In order to answer these questions, I propose a survey experiment in which respondents evaluate an act of delegated violence followed by a government denial of involvement. I query respondents on three key outcomes that reflect whether leaders can delegate to achieve plausible deniability. First, I ask respondents to rate the plausibility of the government's denial. I then ask respondents to assign blame to the government, drawing upon research in psychology to more deeply probe the effects of delegation on blame attribution. Finally, I ask respondents about their favorability toward and preferred level of punishment for the foreign government. These outcomes provide a lens through which we can investigate the causal effect of delegating violence to militias on support for accountability.

This project aims to uncover the the micro-processes enabling states to use militias in order to avoid international punishment. Existing research on plausible deniability has provided indirect evidence to support the theory (Carey, Colaresi, and Mitchell 2015; DiBlasi 2020) whereas this project experimentally tests the causal effect of delegating violence to militias on individual judgments and attitudes. This project is a critical test of this established theory, providing direct evidence on how PGMs provide states with plausible deniability.

The results of the experiment reveal how individuals reason about responsibility for political violence. When leaders delegate violence to PGMs, they avoid some level of blame and punishment, but these effects only obtain for certain militias. However, respondents appear unsatisfied by a simple denial of involvement. Delegating and denying does not completely absolve the government of responsibility and still results in unfavorable evaluations. Given that leaders across the globe increasingly rely on delegation and private military companies for domestic and international security, it is critically important to fully understand how this trend might complicate and undermine traditional accountability mechanisms. Accordingly, this project contributes to research on effective accountability and compliance with international norms and laws. Understanding the effects of delegation on citizens attitudes can inform new or adjusted strategies to hold abusive leaders accountable.

2 Pro-Government Militias and Plausible Deniability

Pro-government militias (PGMs) are perhaps one of the most widespread yet under-recognized political actors across the globe. In the time period between 1981 and 2014, over 90 states, both weak and strong, democracies and autocracies, have collaborated with a PGM at some point. Four attributes distinguish PGMs from other armed militias or special military units. Pro-government militias are (1) independently organized (2) armed groups that are (3) supported or sponsored by the incumbent government yet (4) fall outside of the official military chain of command (Carey, Mitchell, and Lowe 2013). Roughly half of all recorded PGMs are created by the state while the other half form autonomously (Carey, Mitchell, and Paula 2022). States regularly provide PGMs with funding, weapons, and training; however, PGMs may also receive support from local citizens, business people, or foreign governments. PGMs most often coordinate with the state through some link to a state institution or the military, but more than a third of recorded PGMs directly coordinate with the president or an individual in the executive (Carey, Mitchell, and Lowe 2013).

Today, powerful government sponsored militias like the Wagner Group (Russia), the Rapid Support Forces (formerly Janjaweed, Sudan), and the Revolutionary Guard (Iran) influence politics both domestically and internationally. Given this laundry list of negative consequences of PGMs and their continued relevance in international affairs, it is critically important to understand when and why governments collaborate with these groups.

2.1 Unpacking Plausible Deniability

One of the predominant theories of a state's motivation to use PGMs focuses on the plausible deniability afforded by militia usage (Carey, Colaresi, and Mitchell 2015, 2016; DiBlasi 2020; Ambrozik 2019). State leaders, intent on repressing political opponents yet weary of a potential backlash, delegate this repressive violence to militias in order to obfuscate the government's involvement. If and when observers demand an explanation, the leader can deny involvement and appeal to agency slack, claiming that the militia acted independently and that the government could not control the group. Delegating violence to a PGM creates reasonable doubt about the government's culpability, reducing the chance that domestic or international audiences move to hold the government accountable.

In theoretical terms, using militias for plausible deniability is an *informational* strategy aimed at avoiding punishment. The state will only delegate violence to militias when it anticipates some inquiry or punishment for repression. If the state faces zero potential punishments, then it need not delegate violence to militias.[1] Assuming some chance of punishment, however, the information linking state leaders to the perpetrators of repression determines whether the leader is punished. Plausible deniability works by severing or muddying that link. The following sections will more deeply explore how information about state-PGM relationships helps leaders avoid accountability.

2.1.1 Delegation and Information

Delegation and denial aims to cast reasonable doubt on the state's involvement in violence. This strategy is only effective insofar as observers accept that the armed actor may have acted independently. When very little evidence links the government to a PGM, the state can more plausibly deny involvement with the group. As the government's connection to the militia becomes more clear, however, the government is less able to escape blame for the PGM's actions.

The formality of the state-PGM relationship is a key piece of information linking governments to PGMs. In pursuit of plausible deniability, states are more likely to utilize *informal* militias, characterized by a lack of official legal recognition, than *semi-official* militias, which have legal permission to operate (Carey, Colaresi, and Mitchell 2015). Indeed, in their empirical model of PGM usage, Carey et al. (2015) restrict the dependent variable to informal PGMs since states are unlikely to rely on semi-official PGMs for deniability.

1. Reclusive autocracies like North Korea or Turkmenistan are very clear examples of states that would face few repercussions for repressing their citizens or political opponents.

Extending this informational logic, states should have the hardest time avoiding blame when the military commits repressive violence. The direct chain of command connecting leaders to the military should make any denial of involvement implausible. Conversely, states should most easily avoid blame when a truly independent armed group commits violence.

Official legal recognition is just one piece of information that betrays government involvement with PGMs. Alternatively, militias may have historical or family connections to the state leader. Where former colonies gained independence through rebellion, the incipient leader often maintains links to the anti-colonial militia organization (Ahram 2011). In other cases, the members of a PGM may share an ethnicity with the president or have a history of military/ police service, potentially revealing a connection to the government.

2.1.2 Denial

Regardless of the violent actor or available information about the state's involvement, states accused of repression regularly deny and appeal to agency slack. In the aftermath of the Abu Ghraib prison torture scandal, US leaders highlighted their inability control soldiers in a prison in Iraq and largely evaded negative repercussions (Mitchell 2012). Jean Pierre Bemba, a former vice president of the DRC, similarly argued that he could not sufficiently monitor and control his own soldiers and, therefore, had his ICC conviction for crimes against humanity overturned (Ba 2018). These examples illustrate that delegating violence to militias may not be strictly necessary for states to successfully evade punishment. However, delegating to militias complicates the information environment, enhancing the plausibility of the government's denial to relevant audiences.

2.1.3 Audiences and Punishment

Domestic publics, international prosecutors, and foreign governments can punish abusive governments in a variety of ways, both reputational and material. Leaders delegate violence to militias to reshape the information available to these audiences in an attempt to avoid these punishments.

The first line of accountability for abusive leaders is domestic elites and citizens. Carey et al. (2015) envisage that elections are the primary mechanism for this domestic punishment. The use of militias for deniability to a domestic audience should concentrate in "incomplete democracies," since "full democracies" are characterized by free speech and open information such that secrecy would be too difficult to maintain (Carey, Colaresi, and Mitchell 2015, 853). Relatedly, autocracies lack institutional processes for the public to hold the leader accountable and therefore, do not need the deniability afforded by PGMs. Taken together, the ability of a leader to use militias for domestic deniability relies on a particular institutional configuration: the government must be secretive enough to enable the leader to hide their PGM relationship, but not so secretive as to undermine the public's ability to punish the leader in an election. In these circumstances, leaders may delegate for deniability to a domestic audience. This line of accountability underpins one of my chosen support-for-punishment outcomes—government favorability.

While domestic audiences constitute the first layer of accountability, international actors also represent a crucial source of potential punishment, particularly for regimes that depend on external support. States and international organizations have numerous options for punishing abusive leaders.

In the most extreme cases, the International Criminal Court, or some other ad-hoc international tribunal, may attempt to arrest and try the leader for human rights abuses or crimes against humanity. International prosecution has become an increasingly common response to abusive state and militia leaders, improving global human rights compliance (Simmons 2009). In this context, delegating egregious violence to militias aims to cast doubt on the leader's *legal culpability* among international prosecutors and judges—the primary audience responsible for this punishment.

Considering the high evidentiary standard required for a conviction, delegating violence to militias should, in theory, protect leaders from legal punishment. Indeed, Laurent Gbagbo of Cote d'Ivoire avoided conviction for his militia-led attempt at overturning the 2010 election based on insufficient evidence demonstrating that he directly orchestrated the militia violence.[2] However, given the tremendous amount of time and resources required for a trial, international litigation is often reserved for extreme cases of violence. Nevertheless, to capture this line of accountability in the experiment, I query respondents about their support for a UN investigation into the violence.

More commonly, other states levy punishments on abusive leaders. These punishments may include suspensions of foreign aid, sanctions, naming-and-shaming, and even direct military intervention. In their analysis, Carey and coauthors (2015) operationalize the need for deniability with a measure of foreign aid dependence, since states that depend on foreign aid stand to lose more from being caught collaborating with PGMs. They find, indeed, that foreign aid dependence strongly correlates with PGM usage. Diblasi (2020) found that states are more likely to foster new PGM relationships after being named and shamed for abuse in international forums. Based on this research, in the survey, I ask respondents to evaluate whether the abusive government should be sanctioned, lose access to aid, or maintain good international standing.

In attempting to evade these interstate punishments, abusive governments aim to persuade other state leaders *and* other states' citizens of the government's innocence. The most prolific purveyors of foreign aid and external support are democracies. Although democratic leaders set policy, public opinion shapes these decisions, even as it relates to foreign policy (Milner and Tingley 2015). Even though many voters may care less about foreign policy, it still influences voter behavior (Aldrich, Sullivan, and Borgida 1989; Gelpi, Reifler, and Feaver 2007; Tomz, Weeks, and Yarhi-Milo 2020; Heinrich, Kobayashi, and Long 2018). Furthermore, general sentiment, rather than a widespread, immediate public outcry, may be sufficient to influence foreign policymakers since elected officials are careful to consider any

2. Delegating to militias does not guarantee an acquittal. Leaders like Mladić (Serbia) and Kambanda (Rwanda) have been convicted of human rights abuses for militia violence. Conversely, acquittal does not require delegation. Bemba (Democratic Republic of Congo) avoided international conviction, even though soldiers under his direct command massacred civilians.

downstream electoral repercussions for current decisions (Mayhew 2004). In this context, delegating violence to militias aims both to influence democratic policymakers' opinions and to shape domestic public opinion that conditions these policymakers' decisions.

Public sentiment may be directly consequential for abusive states, too. General affect toward a country seriously influences that country's attractiveness for trade, investment, and tourism (Wang 2006). Numerous states have invested significant resources in public diplomacy campaigns in the US, motivated by the desire to increase positive feelings and facilitate deeper cooperation between the country and the US (Hartig 2016; Goldsmith, Horiuchi, and Matush 2021; Bry 2017).

The case of Indonesia and East Timor illustrates the importance of public opinion for punishing abusive foreign leaders. Indonesia attempted to annex East Timor in 1974 after the Portuguese colonial administration collapsed. During the invasion and ensuing occupation, Indonesian forces killed more than 100,000 Timorese citizens (Simpson and Venkatasubramanian 2019). In 1998, after the fall of longstanding Indonesian dictator Suharto, the new leader, Habibie, organized an independence referendum for East Timor. Indonesian military officials, however, staunchly opposed Timorese independence and organized a militia-led terror campaign ahead of the referendum, sparking widespread public outcry and drawing significant international criticism.

Declassified national security documents highlight that US policymakers were fully aware of the Indonesian military's abuses and involvement with these militias. Nevertheless, US officials preferred to continue cooperating and providing aid to Indonesia in order to avoid destabilizing its transition to democracy (Simpson and Venkatasubramanian 2019). However, facing mounting domestic and international pressure to respond to these human rights abuses, President Clinton suspended military aid to Indonesia in 1999 (Marshall, Lamb, and Goldman 1999). Despite US policymakers' offsetting interests in maintaining close ties with the new Indonesian government, public outcry critically shifted US policy toward punishment.

In sum, states face accountability for repression at multiple levels and before multiple audiences. At the highest level, delegation aims to persuade international litigators and judges, providing legal deniability for abusive leaders. State leaders may also delegate to PGMs in order to influence other states' leaders and citizens, aiming to avoid punishments like aid suspensions or sanctions. Finally, in some circumstances, leaders may attempt to use PGMs for domestic deniability.

2.2 Hypotheses

The previous sections have outlined the theory of plausible deniability, highlighting the punishments states face for abuse and detailing how information should shape punishment likelihood. As discussed, the empirical record for delegation and deniability is mixed. In some cases, leaders appear to skirt accountability for militia violence, whereas other leaders avoid punishment without delegating violence or get punished despite delegating violence. This underscores the need for new, direct evidence on the effects of militia-use on blame assessments and punishment likelihood.

The theoretical discussion highlights multiple observable implications in line with plausible deniability theory. The first, most obvious, implication relates to the plausibility of the leader's denial. As the name of the theory suggests, when leaders delegate violence to militias, the leader's subsequent denial of involvement should be perceived as more plausible:

> **H1 Denial Plausibility:** When violence is committed by an informal pro-government militia instead of the state military, observers should view the government's denial of involvement as more plausible.

However, the previous discussion emphasizes that states delegate violence to militias to avoid punishment. Whether a denial is viewed as plausible only matters if it results in better tangible outcomes for the state. Put another way, the nominal plausibility of the denial is less important than the state's likelihood to be punished. Psychologically, observers' willingness to punish a foreign government hinges on perceptions of the government's blameworthiness. These considerations lead to two, related expectations: when leaders delegate violence, observers should assign less blame and support fewer punishments for the government

> **H2 Blame:** When violence is committed by an informal pro-government militia instead of the state military, the government should receive less blame for the violence.

> **H3 Punishment:** When violence is committed by an informal pro-government militias instead of the state military, observers should oppose punishment (express more support) for the government.

Each of these hypotheses reflects a different dimension of plausible deniability theory. Delegating and denying involvement should be seen as more plausible than using centrally controlled agents and should result in less blame and punishment for the government. Each of these expectations should find empirical support if delegating to PGMs operates according to theory.

3 Experiment

Delegating violence to militias is an informational strategy aimed at avoiding punishment. In order to test whether this strategy has its theorized effects, I propose a survey experiment in which respondents read a hypothetical news story about an instance of ethnic violence, delegated or not, followed by a government denial of involvement. Respondents then evaluate the plausibility of the government's denial, the foreign government's blameworthiness, and whether the government should be punished. By experimentally manipulating details about the violent actor, I can evaluate how delegation shifts observers' reactions to the violence.[3]

3. The pre-registration for this project can be seen here: https://osf.io/nwjgr/overview?view_only=2d2f2851b5c747aab8a1e11897492e0b. I have previously attempted to evaluate plausible deniability theory with a different survey experimental design. The previous survey featured various details that complicated the interpretation of results. The appendix features the previous pre-registration link, an in-depth discussion of these problems, and how the present design overcomes them.

3.1 The Sample

I recruit roughly 1,500 US citizens through Connect by CloudResearch as the sample for this experiment. Connect is an opt-in online survey vendor similar to Amazon's MTurk, but participants on Connect have been shown to pay closer attention and provide higher quality responses than respondents on MTurk (Stagnaro et al. 2024). The sample consists of voting-age American citizens, without additional quotas or requirements. The recovered sample demographics are roughly representative of the US population, with a slight skew toward Democrats who make up about 60% of the sample.

In the original theory, the analysis predicts PGM usage with a measure of state dependence on foreign aid from democracies (Carey, Colaresi, and Mitchell 2015). Given that elites control foreign aid, the ideal sample for this project would be foreign-policy makers in a democracy. In the absence of a readily available elite sample, however, I rely on a sample of US citizens.

The US is the greatest purveyor of foreign aid and many states pay close attention to US public opinion (Wang 2006), therefore, US citizens are a meaningful sample for testing this theory. Their blame assessments and punishment preferences are theoretically important quantities to consider. Furthermore, recent survey research has demonstrated that public opinion on foreign policy in the US generally aligns with how citizens in other democracies reason about foreign policy (Gravelle, Reifler, and Scotto 2017, 2021). Insofar as democracies are a target audience for PGM usage, this sample will provide meaningful insight into how democratic citizens reason about government accountability for violence.

3.2 Survey Experimental Design

The full survey experiment consists of three phases: pre-treatment, delegation, and denial. The pre-treatment phase begins with a short survey collecting demographics and other respondent-level characteristics. Participants then read and react to a brief descriptive vignette about the setting for the violence—a hypothetical country named Centralia. After introducing the case, I ask respondents about their favorability toward Centralia and their preferences for punishment—the first collection of outcomes related to **H3 Punishment**. These pre-treatment reactions provide a benchmark for understanding treatment effects.

The delegation phase begins with the primary treatment vignette—a story about violent ethnic attacks in Centralia. The experiment manipulates whether the Centralian military or one of three different militia groups committed the violence. After this treatment, respondents evaluate the Centralian government's blameworthiness and report their support for punishing Centralia.

In the final, denial phase all respondents, regardless of the treatment condition, read a press release in which the president of Centralia denies involvement in the violence. After reading the government's denial, participants react to the denial and re-evaluate government blameworthiness and punishment deservingness.

This segmented design provides multiple opportunities to collect outcome measures, allowing me to trace how each additional piece of evidence shifts respondents' perceptions. Repeated measures of this kind have been shown to enhance statistical precision without altering recovered treatment effects (Clifford, Sheagley, and Piston 2021). The complete survey draft is available in the Appendix.

3.2.1 Pre-Treatment Phase

The pre-treatment phase begins with a series of demographic questions including partisanship. Respondents then complete a 10-question battery estimating their foreign policy orientation (Wittkopf 1990; Holsti 2009; Rathbun et al. 2016). These questions probe respondents' preferences over US international involvement, and, by extension, reveal how they view "foreign countries" more generally. These predispositions condition an individual's willingness to trust and/or punish foreign governments. In line with standard practice (Rathbun et al. 2016), I aggregate responses to these questions into three component indices and include these as control variables in my statistical models. To filter out inattentive respondents, I include a guided-response attention check question randomly presented during the foreign policy orientation battery. The attention check mimics one of the foreign policy orientation statements but instructs respondents to select a specific answer.

Respondents then read a brief description of Centralia—the hypothetical state where this experiment is set. The vignette describes Centralia as a democracy that has recovered from a history of ethnic violence between its two primary groups—northerners and southerners. The president of Centralia is supported primarily by southerners but claims to govern on behalf of all citizens. Although PGMs are present across a wide range of states and domestic contexts (Carey, Mitchell, and Lowe 2013), many of the most well-known PGMs operate in states with deep ethnic cleavages (Abbs, Clayton, and Thomson 2020) and legacies of organized political violence (Aliyev 2020; Steinert, Steinert, and Carey 2019). Centralia is, thus, an archetypal setting for PGM usage. I use a hypothetical country to avoid introducing "charged" contextual cues that could systematically bias perceptions of the foreign government independent of treatment information (Brutger et al. 2023).

After the case introduction, I collect the first round of responses for outcomes related to **H3 Punishment**.

3.2.2 Delegation Phase

Respondents then read a short news story about a week-long campaign of violence against Northern communities in Centralia. Details in this vignette are modeled after real-world news coverage of ethnic violent attacks. After reading a description of the violence, respondents receive the primary treatment—a short paragraph about the perpetrator of the violence and their connection to the government.

Repondents are randomly assigned to one of four treatment groups corresponding to a specific violent actor: the military, a semi-official PGM, an informal PGM, and an independent militia. In the control group, the Centralian military commits the violent attacks. According to the theory of plausible deniability, states delegate violence to PGMs because using official state agents, like the military, would betray government involvement. Thus, military violence furnishes the relevant theoretical baseline for testing whether PGMs enhance deniability.

The core treatment group of interest is the INFORMAL PGM condition. The original test of plausible deniability focused exclusively on informal PGMs because of they often have unclear connections to government officials and lack official legal authorization to operate (Carey, Colaresi, and Mitchell 2015). To proxy these details, in the vignette I highlight that the group openly supports the government and that political opponents have accused the government of funding the group. Respondents in the INFORMAL PGM condition should assign less blame and support fewer punishment than in the MILITARY condition. This is the core expectation of plausible deniability theory.

The other two conditions provide theoretical benchmarks to contextualize this main effect. Similar to informal PGMs, semi-official openly support the government, but semi-official groups are legally authorized to operate and are often funded by the government. Existing research on plausible deniability provides unclear expectations for semi-official PGMs. On the one hand, semi-official groups are independently organized and separate from the military chain of command, therefore may be harder for government officials to control (Carey, Colaresi, and Mitchell 2016). On the other hand, semi-official groups have clear, legal connections to the government and should garner more blame than other types of PGMs (Carey, Colaresi, and Mitchell 2015). Reactions in this condition shed light on whether semi-official PGMs provide state officials with any deniability. Furthermore, responses in this condition clarify whether simple institutional separation is enough to earn states deniability or whether auxiliary information about PGM-government connections undermines the effect of delegation.

Finally, the INDEPENDENT MILITIA condition represents the maximal distance between the state and the violent agent. Therefore, responses in this condition help establish how much blame persists in cases where state involvement is genuinely absent. This benchmark can thus illustrate the *additional* amount of blame assigned for having connections with a violent PGM. Whereas the MILITARY condition provides a floor, the INDEPENDENT MILITIA condition provides a ceiling for blame avoidance.

Taken together, these four experimental conditions enable us to broadly sketch how delegating violence shapes perceptions of government blameworthiness and punishment deservingness. The core expectation of plausible deniability theory focuses narrowly on the comparison between informal PGMs and the military. The other two conditions contextualize this main effect and uncover the microfoundations of the theory. Although the SEMI-OFFICIAL PGM and INDEPENDENT MILITIA conditions do not feature in my hypotheses, the logic of plausible deniability theory suggests ordinal effect sizes. If information about government-PGM connections drives punishment as theorized, then the MILITARY condition should result in the least deniability, followed by the SEMI-OFFICIAL PGM and then INFORMAL PGM conditions. The INDEPENDENT MILITIA condition should earn leaders the most deniability.

After the violence and delegation vignettes, respondents evaluate the government's blameworthiness (**H2**) and update their favorability ratings and willingness to punish Centralia (**H3**).

3.2.3 Denial Phase

Following this second round of outcome questions, all respondents read a statement by the president of Centralia denying involvement in the violence.

Because every participant reads the same denial, it is not a treatment in strict experimental terms—there is no control condition. However, I collect responses for **H2 Blame** and **H3 Punishment** immediately before the denial. Assuming that time is not a confound,[4] these pre-denial judgments approximate a control condition, enabling a before-and-after comparison to estimate the denial's effect.

4. In practical terms, this assumption stipulates that responses following some placebo treatment in a control condition would not systematically differ from the pre-denial measure of the same outcome.

The theory of plausible deniability suggests that the denial should have heterogenous effects across treatment condition. When violence is delegated to a PGM, the denial should be more persuasive, absolving the government of relatively more blame than in the MILITARY condition. Although I do not have an explicit hypothesis about the conditional effect of the denial, I compare pre- and post-denial outcomes to explore whether delegation increases the denial's persuasiveness.

After the president's statement, respondent's rate the plausibility of the denial (**H1**) and re-assess government blameworthiness (**H2**) and deserved punishments (**H3**). This round of outcomes constitutes the second collection for **H2** and the third collection for **H3**.

3.3 Evaluating Hypotheses

This survey design will enable me to fruitfully explore how observers interpret and react to delegated violence. In the theory section, I present three hypotheses about these reactions. This section details the specific outcome questions I will use to evaluate these hypotheses.

3.3.1 H1 Denial Plausibility

The first hypothesis relates to the plausibility of the government's denial. Given that "plausibility" is a relatively ill-defined concept, the outcome questions focus on two constituent judgments: whether the government is telling the truth and whether it is possible that the actor behaved independently. These are two key beliefs that the government seeks to change by delegating violence to militias. Leaders want observers to truly believe that the government wasn't involved in the violence, and that the militia acted alone.

To create a single measure of denial plausibility, I standardize and add these two measures together to create the Plausible Deniability Index (PD Index). This index will serve as the primary outcome measure for **H1 Denial Plausibility**. I will also separately analyze and discuss responses to the two components to clearly unpack how deniability operates. These models are labeled *Gov. Truth* and *Rogue Actor*, respectively.

3.3.2 H2 Blame

The second hypothesis concerns the Centralian government's blameworthiness for the violence. I begin by asking respondents to assign a level of blame to the government on a 10-point scale. This blame rating serves as the main outcome measure for tests of **H2 Blame**.

Blame, however, is a complex judgment, drawing upon numerous contextual considerations such as foresight, intention, motivation, or mitigating circumstances (Alicke 2000). To better understand respondents' reasoning about blame in this situation, I draw upon one of the predominant psychological theories of blame known as the Path Model of Blame (Malle, Guglielmo, and Monroe 2014). In the Path Model, after some negative event, observers first consider whether the agent—the government, in this case—*caused* and *intended* the negative outcome—violence. For intentional action, the agent's *justifications* inform blame judgments. To assign blame for unintended consequences, observers consider the agent's *obligation* and *capacity* to have prevented the negative outcome.

For the purposes of this experiment, respondents rate their level of agreement with three statements corresponding to three of these considerations: causality, intention, and capacity to prevent.[5] Causality and intention tap the government's generative role in orchestrating the violence. This is the first potential blame-off-ramp for government leaders—if the government was uninvolved in generating the violence, then they should avoid blame. Capacity to prevent, on the other hand, reflects the government's remediative role in preventing violence and controlling violent actors. This is the second way in which governments may avoid blame for delegated violence—by losing control over its agents.

Questions about these three considerations are included primarily for exploratory purposes but will shed additional light on how delegation influences blame assessments. If

5. I choose to exclude obligation and justification based on the goals of the experiment. The treatment information should not influence respondents' perception of the government's obligation to protect citizens from violence. Similarly, the experiment is designed to test the effects of a denial, whereas justification is an alternative blame-avoidance strategy. In the absence of any justifying appeals, the treatment should not change whether respondents felt the violence was justified.

observers believe that the government was truly uninvolved, then this belief should shift estimates of government causality and intention. Similarly, responses to the capacity-to-prevent question will illustrate the persuasiveness of the rogue actor claim—if the government cannot control the violent actor, then it may avoid blame for the actor's behaviors. Understanding whether these appeals impact one consideration more than another further elucidates how leaders might skirt accountability. I complete the first collection of these outcome questions after the delegation phase and the second collection after the denial.

3.3.3 H3 Punishment

The final hypothesis concerns the respondents' support for punishing the foreign government. Among the three hypothesized effects of delegation, reducing the likelihood of punishment is arguably the most important. As discussed in the theory section, states delegate violence to PGMs in order to avoid both reputational and material punishments.

I begin this series of questions by asking respondents to report their favorability toward Centralia on a 0-10 scale. Reduced favorability among international citizens may, itself, be a punishment for states. This measure also proxies electoral punishment from a domestic audience. Furthermore, favorability ratings align with general punishment support, enabling even low knowledge respondents to provide meaningful reactions to the treatment information. In this sense, this outcome question taps a specific punishment for abusive leaders but also serves as a gauge for general support for punishment.

Participants then report their preferences over four punishments for Centralia including being sanctioned, losing access to foreign assistance, losing good standing internationally, and being investigated by the UN. Sanctions and aid suspensions are key material punishments highlighted in the existing literature on plausible deniability. A loss of good standing and UN investigation focus more on the reputational punishments facing abusive leaders. States delegate violence to avoid being named-and-shamed in international forums (DiBlasi 2020), motivating the specific question about international good standing. Additionally, beyond harming the states reputation, a UN investigation can lead to ICC litigation. In sum, each of these measures align with a theorized punishment facing abusive leaders and, together, provide clear insight into how delegation influences accountability.

Just as with the Plausible Deniability Index for **H1**, I standardize and add these four punishments together to create a single Punishment Index to evaluate **H3**. I also report results for each punishment measure separately.

3.3.4 Model Specifications

I use OLS models to estimate the effect of delegating violence on these outcomes. Since I only collect responses for **H1 Denial Plausibility** once during the denial phase, I analyze responses by including each of the three treatment conditions as regressors.

The model specification for repeated measures of government blame (**H2**) or punishment deservingness (**H3**) can be seen in the equation below. As shown, I stack responses in the two, post-treatment collection rounds—denoted by the t_1, t_2 subscripts—and include an interacted term for post-denial responses. The top line of the equation models delegation phase outcomes and the terms featuring the denial phase indicator—$\mathbb{1}$(Post-Denial)—model denial phase responses. I include participant random effects in all interacted models to account for the dependence between the two outcome rounds. All models include controls for demographics, foreign policy orientation, and pre-treatment favorability toward Centralia,[6] collectively represented by $\boldsymbol{\alpha X}$.

6. For symmetry, when modeling different outcomes for **H3 Punishment**, I use the identical pre-treatment measure as a control. For example, in the sanctions model, I control for the respondents pre-treatment response to the sanction question.

$$
\begin{aligned}
Blame_{t_1,t_2} = & \alpha_0 + \alpha_1(\text{Semi-Official}) + \alpha_2(\text{Informal}) + \alpha_3(\text{Independent}) \\
& + \alpha_4 \mathbb{1}(\text{Post-Denial}) \\
& + \alpha_5 \mathbb{1}(\text{Post-Denial}) \times (\text{Semi-Official}) \\
& + \alpha_6 \mathbb{1}(\text{Post-Denial}) \times (\text{Informal}) \\
& + \alpha_7 \mathbb{1}(\text{Post-Denial}) \times (\text{Independent}) \\
& + \boldsymbol{\alpha X} + RE
\end{aligned}
$$

4 Results

This survey design enables us to directly evaluate the expectations of plausible deniability theory. In this section, I first examine whether delegation makes government denials more believable (**H1**). I then assess whether delegation alters perceptions of government blameworthiness for the violence (**H2**) while further probing the specific components of blame. Finally, I consider whether these changes in attribution translate into reduced favorability or support for punishing the government (**H3**). Regression tables for all models are reported in the Appendix.

4.1 H1 Denial Plausibility

We begin by considering whether the name of the theory itself finds support: does delegating violence to PGMs result in more plausible denials? Table 1 displays these results. The first column is a model of the Plausible Deniability Index. The second and third show results from the two component questions on government truthfulness or the rogue actor claim.

First, the theory's primary expectation finds support. Respondents found the denial of involvement more plausible in the INFORMAL PGM condition than in the MILITARY condition. This effect is consistent across both component models, too. Participants tended both to believe the relative truthfulness of the denial and to concede that the actor may have gone rogue, acting without direction or coordination from the government. Therefore, in terms of expressed beliefs, delegating violence to informal militias appears to buy states plausible deniability.

Table 1: Regression results for H1 Plausible Deniability. Informal groups earn states deniability whereas semi-official groups do not.

	Dependent variable:		
	PD Index	Gov. Truth	Rogue Actor
	(1)	(2)	(3)
Semi-Official	-0.008	-0.183^{***}	0.169^{**}
	(0.066)	(0.067)	(0.069)
Informal	0.520^{***}	0.422^{***}	0.456^{***}
	(0.067)	(0.068)	(0.070)
Independent	0.809^{***}	0.662^{***}	0.705^{***}
	(0.067)	(0.068)	(0.069)
Constant	-1.518^{***}	-1.122^{***}	-1.445^{***}
	(0.415)	(0.420)	(0.432)
Observations	1,512	1,512	1,512
R^2	0.195	0.175	0.129
Adjusted R^2	0.182	0.161	0.115
Residual Std. Error	0.904	0.916	0.941
F Statistic	15.029^{***}	13.122^{***}	9.157^{***}

Note: *p<0.1; **p<0.05; ***p<0.01
All models include the same set of controls.
All DVs are mean-standardized.
Analytical standard errors.

Across all models, independent militias earned the most deniability and these coefficients are significantly larger ($p < 0.001$) than those in the INFORMAL PGM condition. This pattern reveals the importance of information about government-PGM ties. Even being accused of collaborating with a PGM reduces the state's ability to persuasively deny involvement, but if states can successfully hide their connections, they can more easily deny.

In line with this focus on information, semi-official groups do not appear to provide states with deniability. In the first, *PD Index* model, the coefficient on semi-official PGMs is null, suggesting that states are no better off delegating to a semi-official PGM than using the military. The component models illustrate the competing considerations underlying this null effect. Participants question the government's truthfulness in the *Gov. Truth* model but admit that a semi-official PGM is more likely to act independently than the military in the *Rogue Actor* model.

Some may debate the relative importance of government truthfulness for earning deniability, however. If deniability simply hinges on the persuasiveness of the rogue actor appeal, then perhaps semi-official groups *can* provide states with deniability. Truthfulness reflects strong plausibility whereas the rogue actor claim taps a weaker form of plausibility. Carey et al. (2015) explicitly discuss this: "Even flimsy denials of responsibility for the activities of 'rogue elements' in these [PGMs] may prove sufficient to create some reasonable doubt about the government's accountability" (853). These results suggest that using semi-official PGMs certainly renders a denial flimsy. But, based on these results alone, it is unclear how much deniability semi-official PGMs provide. The following sections on government blame and punishment deservingness will shed additional light on whether using semi-official PGMs leads to better practical outcomes.

4.2 H2 Blame

Turning to perceptions of blame, in Figure 1 we see very similar patterns. Informal militias appear to absolve the government of blame. In the MILITARY condition, respondents assign the government 7.5 out of 10 blame-points, but in the INFORMAL PGM condition, governments only receive about 5.5 blame-points. Independent militias garner even less blame (5), reinforcing the idea that even accusations of a connection decrease achieved deniability.

Semi-official groups, on the other hand, earn the government just as much blame as the military. Despite the potential persuasiveness of the rogue-actor claim in the previous discussion, semi-official groups do not reduce the government's perceived blameworthiness. By this measure, semi-official groups do not appear to provide states with plausible deniability.

The repeated outcome measures for blame also enable us to consider the effect of the

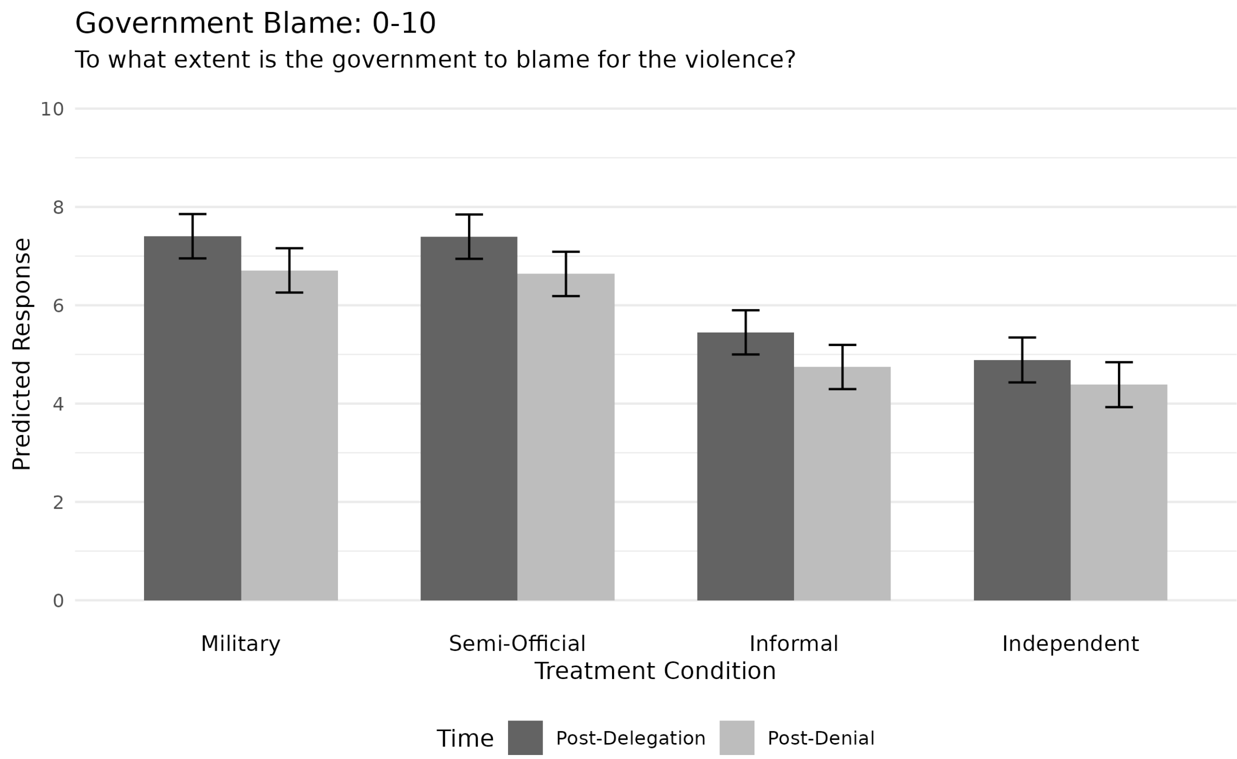

Figure 1: Predicted responses for the blame assignment outcome. Informal and Independent militias earn relatively less blame. The denial is weakly, but consistently effective across each treatment condition. In all cases, a significant amount of blame persists.

denial on blame estimates. Comparing responses before and after the denial within each treatment condition, we see that the denial is weakly, but consistently persuasive. On average, the denial reduced blame estimates by about 0.7 points, regardless of who committed the violence. This consistency adds critical nuance to the conclusions from the first hypothesis. Results for **H1** suggest that respondents *believe* the denial more in the delegated conditions; however, that belief does not absolve Centralia of relatively more blame. Denying involvement in PGM violence appears no more persuasive than denying military violence.

Taken together, these results support the primary expectations of plausible deniability but also hint at the weakness of delegation and denial as an accountability avoidance strategy. As further evidence to this second conclusion, consider that Centralia still earns a significant amount of blame (5 out of 10) in the INDEPENDENT PGM condition. To unpack why this blame persists even when the government is uninvolved, we should consider the three components of blame: causality, intention, and capacity to prevent.

4.2.1 Blame Components

Figure 2 displays results for the three components of blame. First, delegating primarily shifts estimates of the government's causality and intention. Respondents are much more likely to doubt the government's generative role in the violence when committed by an informal or independent militia. Semi-official militias are, once again, no better than the military for avoiding blame along these two dimensions.

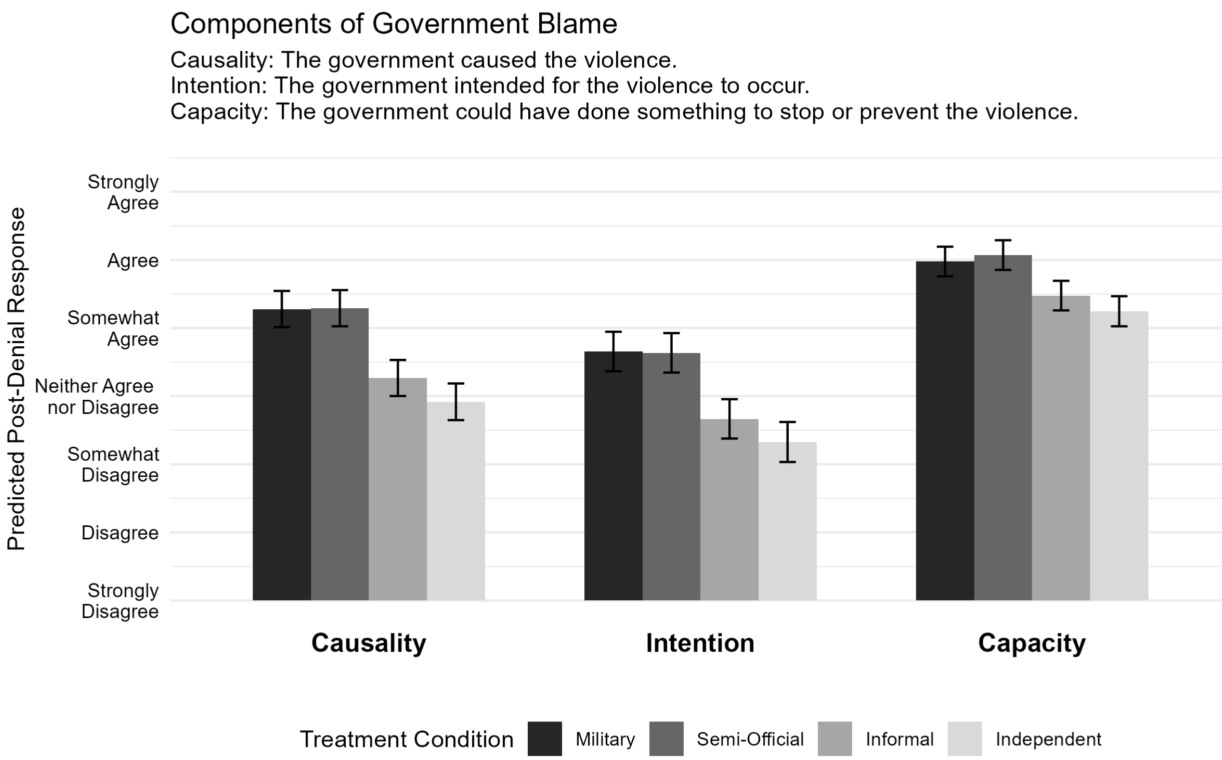

Figure 2: Predicted post-denial responses for the components of blame. When the government delegates violence, respondents are less likely to think that the government caused or intended the violence; however, across all conditions, respondents agreed that the government could have done something to stop or prevent the violence.

Importantly, however, across all conditions, respondents tended to agree that the government could have done something to stop or prevent the violence. Ultimately, governments are responsible for protecting citizens and, in this scenario, it appears that the government has not done enough to fulfill that obligation. This finding hints at the weakness of denial, alone, as an accountability avoidance strategy. Simply denying involvement is an insufficient response to the violence, driving observers to assign some blame to the government despite its lack of involvement in generating the violence. The final analysis for **H3 Punishment** provides further evidence on the insufficiency of denial for maintaining a positive reputation and avoiding accountability.

4.3 H3 Punishment

4.3.1 Favorability

The previous sections have demonstrated that delegating violence to PGMs and denying involvement appears more plausible and helps governments avoid blame relative to using the military; however, the ultimate goal of using PGMs is to avoid reputational and material punishments for the violence.

The first set of results for **H3** concern respondents' favorability toward Centralia. As shown in Figure 3, when the government delegates to an informal group, they earn about 4 points of favorability on a 10-point scale—one more point of favorability than the military condition. Independent groups earn the most favorability, scoring about 4.5 out of 10. Conversely, semi-official groups are viewed least favorably, earning a measly 2.5 points compared to the military's 3 points. Having clear connections to a PGM but denying involvement anyway incurs an additional penalty. These results, once again, support the primary expectation of plausible deniability theory.

The effect of the denial on favorability ratings is consistent across treatment conditions, mirroring the results for blame, with one critical difference. Whereas denial seems to absolve the government of some blame—0.7 points out of 10—it does not meaningfully shift favorability ratings. On average, Centralia is only viewed 0.25 points more favorably after denying involvement.[7] Semi-official groups recover slightly more favorability after a denial,

7. The small effect on favorability achieves traditional levels of statistical significance; however, 0.25 out

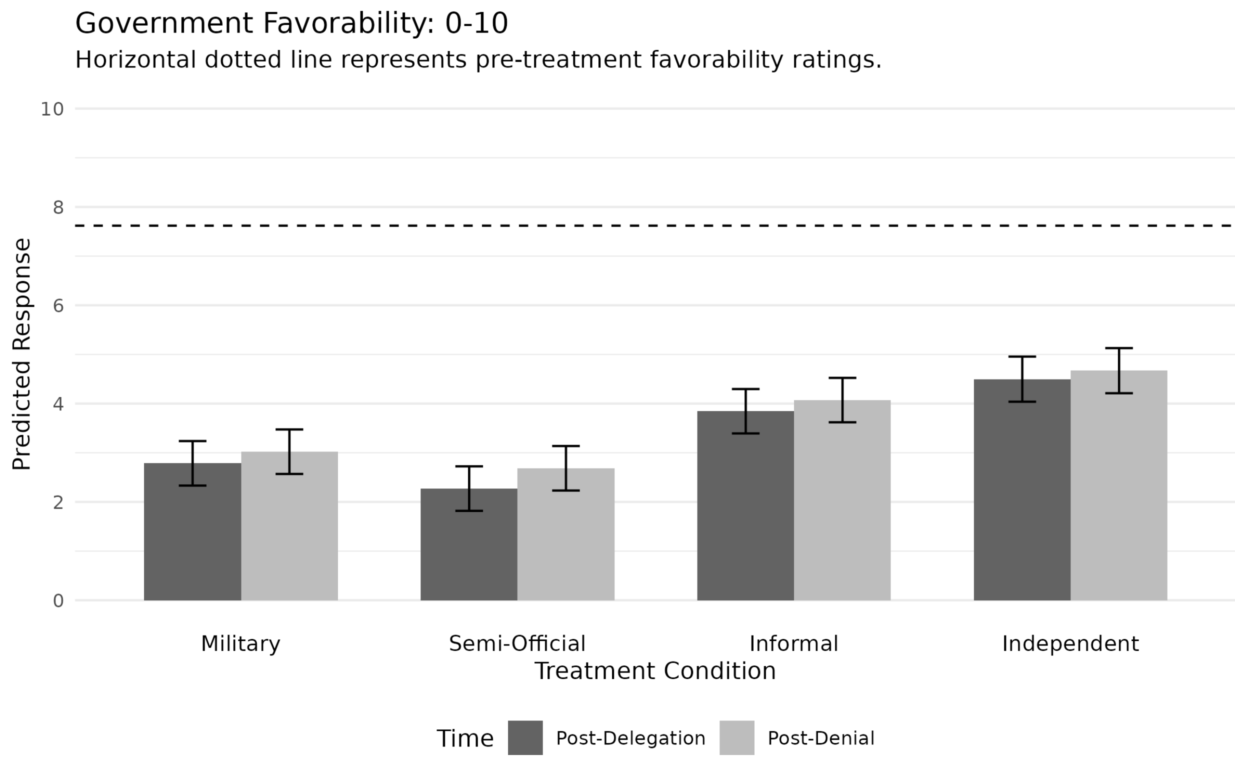

Figure 3: Favorability toward Centralia by treatment condition, pre- and post-denial. Semi-official groups earn the least favorability, yet across all conditions, the government fails to achieve more than 5 our of 10 favorability points.

but even after this relative boost, these groups still earn Centralia less favorability than the military. This finding reinforces the idea that denials are relatively no more persuasive after delegating violence compared to using the official military.

Lastly, the results for favorability feature similar levels of residual disapproval in the INDEPENDENT PGM condition. In Figure 3, the horizontal dotted line represents average pre-treatment favorability ratings. Compared to this benchmark, demonstrated violence, regardless of the actor committing it, damages the state's reputation. This pattern aligns with the previous finding on blame, and highlights the insufficiency of delegation and denial as a strategy for retaining a positive reputation.

of 10 points is practically negligible.

4.3.2 Support for Punishment

The final set of results focuses on support for various punishments for Centralia. Figure 4 displays results from the Punishment Index, and Figure 5 disaggregates the index into its four components.

The results for the punishment index echo previous findings. Support for punishment is highest in the military and semi-official conditions and tapers off in the informal and independent conditions. The denial has no effect on support for punishment—pre- and post-denial responses were statistically indistinguishable from one another. And manifest violence, regardless of actor, increases support for punishment.

The results from the components of the punishment index provide a final insight into how citizens reason about delegated violence. The first three components of punishment draw

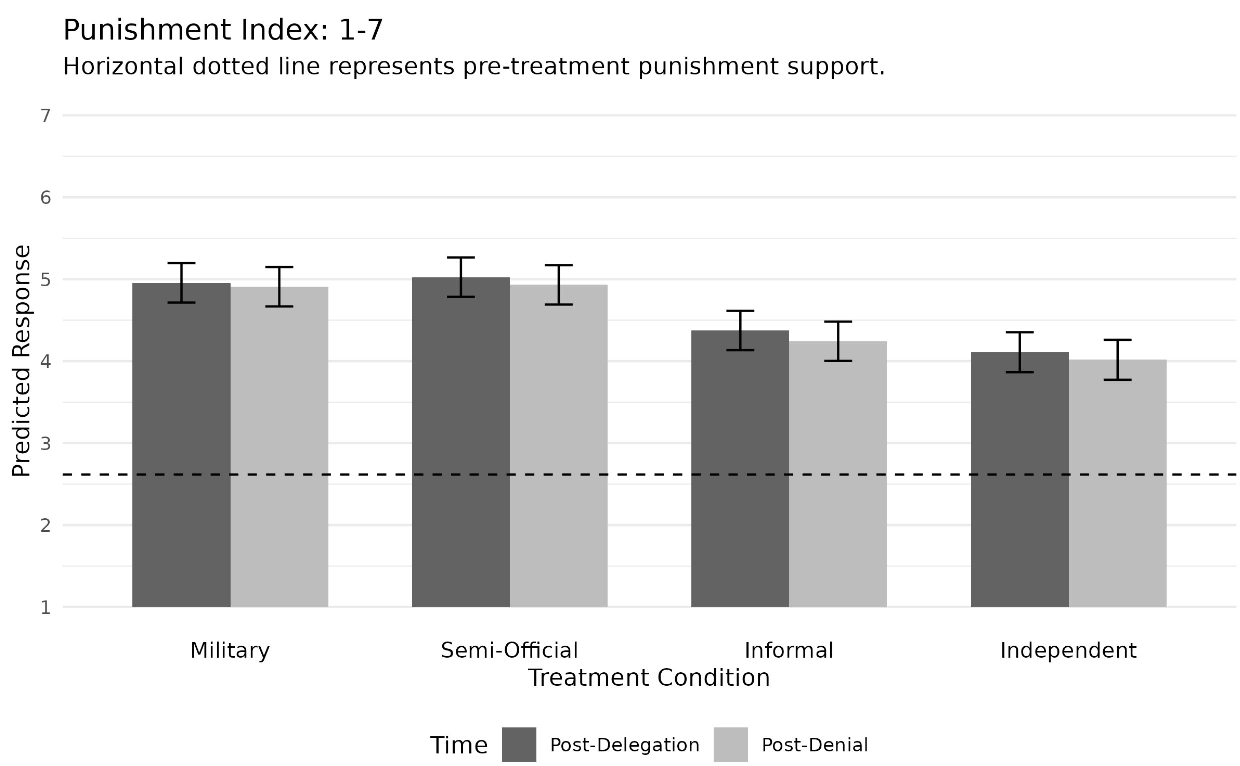

Figure 4: Support for punishment by treatment condition, pre- and post-denial. Informal and independent militias reap relatively less punishment support, but the denial has no effect on support for punishment.

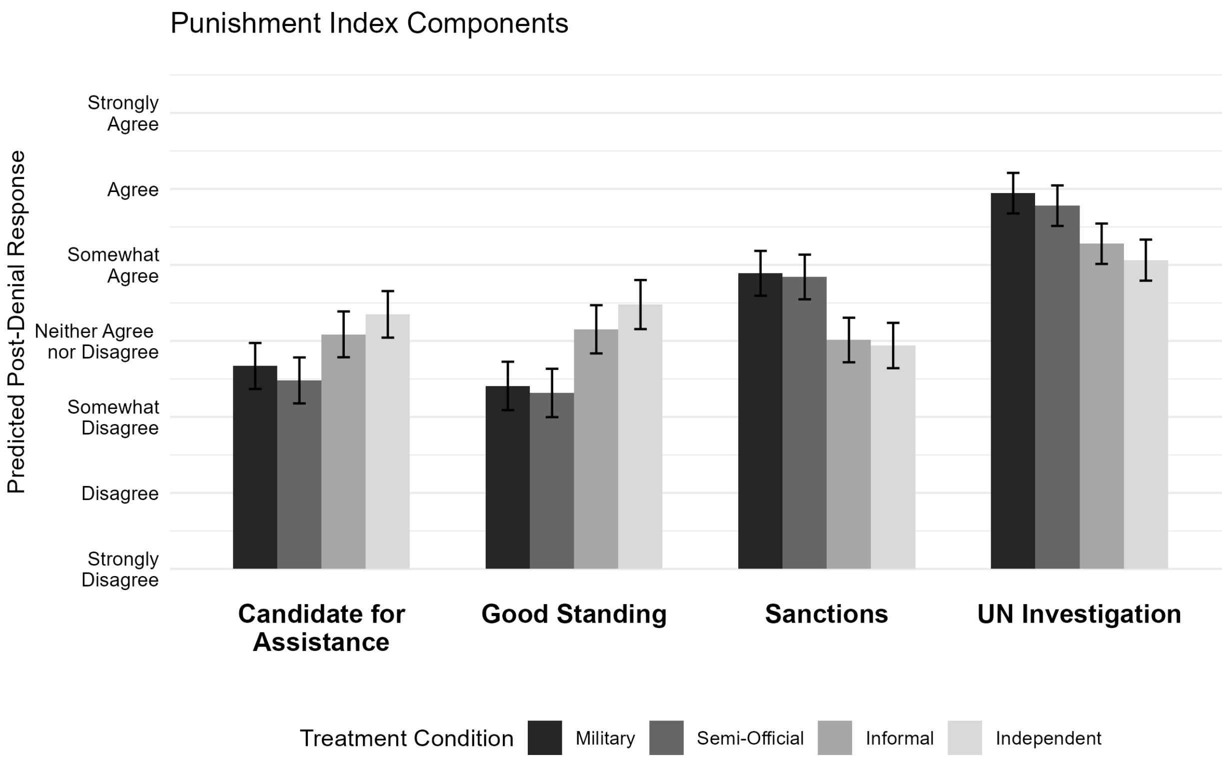

Figure 5: Predicted post-denial responses to the four punishment components. Responses for assistance, good standing, and sanctions differ significantly across treatment conditions. However, in general, most respondents supported a further UN investigation into Centralia.

significantly different responses across treatment conditions. Informal and independent militias garner relatively less support for punishments related to foreign assistance, international good standing, and sanctions. However, in all conditions, participants supported further investigation by the UN. Although delegating may forestall more severe material punishments, it does not stop observers from asking questions and wanting answers.

5 Conclusion

The theory of plausible deniability stipulates that governments delegate violence to pro-government militias so that leaders can deny involvement and skirt accountability for repression. This project directly tests this proposition, tracing how observers react to instances of delegated violence while more deeply exploring the microfoundations of this process.

The results of the survey experiment generally support the expectations of plausible deniability theory, with some interesting nuances. Informal PGMs, compared to the military, generate less government blame and reduce support for punishment. The institutional separation of the informal PGM from the government earns the state plausible deniability. Independent PGMs consistently out-perform informal groups, highlighting the importance of information about the government-PGM connection: even rumored connections can increase perceptions of government blameworthiness. Semi-official PGMs, on the other hand, perform just as poorly as the military on most measures. Despite the fact that respondents are more willing to accept a rogue-actor excuse for semi-official PGM violence, these groups do not absolve the government of relatively more blame or punishment than the military. In the literature on plausible deniability, evidence on semi-official groups is mixed (Carey, Colaresi, and Mitchell 2016); however, this analysis has demonstrated that using these groups hardly helps states avoid accountability.

This project has also provided additional context and nuance to our understanding of delegation, denial, and accountability for violence. First, the results here indicate that denial is weak, but consistently persuasive for all violent actors. Denying involvement in military violence appears just as effective as denying involvement in PGM violence. Delegation does not make denials any more plausible. Moreover, denials are only weakly effective at avoiding blame and punishment. Denying results in slightly less blame for the government, but does not meaningfully increase favorability or decrease support for punishing the state. Denial is an insufficient response to the violence. Across all conditions, respondents agreed that the government could have done something to address the violence and supported additional UN investigation into Centralia.

This final point speaks to the idea that manifest violence harms states' reputations, regardless of delegation or state involvement. The literature on PGMs and plausible deniability highlights PGMs' value for punishment avoidance (Carey, Colaresi, and Mitchell 2015) and reputation management (DiBlasi 2020). The results from this test illustrate that

PGMs provide a relative advantage over the military, but in absolute terms, observers dislike violence and believe that the government is, at least, partially to blame. Simply denying involvement is an insufficient response and leads citizens to support additional investigation into the events. States that are truly interested in maintaining a *positive* reputation should do more to remediate the violence or, better yet, find ways to achieve their political goals without violence.

The limitations of this project provide clear avenues for continued research. This project focuses on interstate accountability mechanisms such as sanctions and aid. However, state leaders face accountability at multiple levels, including domestically. Future work should begin exploring how audiences react to delegated violence domestically and how delegation shifts perceptions of government responsibility. Furthermore, this project focuses narrowly on one country and one accountability avoidance strategy, but PGMs operate in many different places and states have many options for avoiding punishment beyond simply denying involvement. Additional contextual information about ongoing violence, the target of the attacks, or other mitigating circumstances might shift perceptions of government blameworthiness. State leaders might also attempt to justify the violence with offsetting claims or start military counter-operations against the militia in an attempt to demonstrate its blamelessness. Future experimental work might vary any of these details to more deeply probe the influence of delegation on accountability for violence.

References

Abbs, Luke, Govinda Clayton, and Andrew Thomson. 2020. "The Ties That Bind: Ethnicity, Pro-government Militia, and the Dynamics of Violence in Civil War." *Journal of Conflict Resolution* 64 (5): 903–932.

Ahram, Ariel I. 2011. *Proxy Warriors: The Rise and Fall of State-Sponsored Militias.* Stanford University Press.

Aldrich, John H, John L Sullivan, and Eugene Borgida. 1989. "Foreign affairs and issue voting: Do presidential candidates "waltz before a blind audience?"." *American Political Science Review* 83 (1): 123–141.

Alicke, Mark D. 2000. "Culpable control and the psychology of blame." *Psychological bulletin* 126 (4): 556.

Aliyev, Huseyn. 2020. "Pro-regime militias and civil war duration." *Terrorism and Political Violence* 32 (3): 630–650.

Ambrozik, Caitlin. 2019. "Not whether, but when? Governments' use of militias in war." *Security Studies* 28 (5): 870–900.

Ba, Oumar. 2018. "What Jean-Pierre Bemba's acquittal by the ICC means." Aljazeera, June 13, 2018. Accessed February 27, 2025. https://www.aljazeera.com/opinions/2018/6/13/what-jean-pierre-bembas-acquittal-by-the-icc-means.

Baker, Andy. 2015. "Race, paternalism, and foreign aid: Evidence from US public opinion." *American Political Science Review* 109 (1): 93–109.

BBC. 2021. "Ivory Coast's ex-President Gbagbo free to go home after ICC acquittal," March 31, 2021. Accessed February 27, 2025. https://www.bbc.com/news/world-africa-56595150.

Brutger, Ryan, Joshua D Kertzer, Jonathan Renshon, Dustin Tingley, and Chagai M Weiss. 2023. “Abstraction and detail in experimental design.” *American Journal of Political Science* 67 (4): 979–995.

Bry, Sandra H. 2017. “Brazil’s soft-power strategy: The political aspirations of South–South development cooperation.” *Foreign Policy Analysis* 13 (2): 297–316.

Carey, Sabine, Michael Colaresi, and Neil Mitchell. 2015. “Governments, Informal Links to Militias, and Accountability.” *Journal of Conflict Resolution* 59 (5): 850–876.

———. 2016. “Risk mitigation, regime security, and militias: Beyond coup-proofing.” *International Studies Quarterly* 60 (1): 59–72.

Carey, Sabine C, Neil J Mitchell, and Will Lowe. 2013. “States, the security sector, and the monopoly of violence: A new database on pro-government militias.” *Journal of Peace Research* 50 (2): 249–258.

Carey, Sabine C, Neil J Mitchell, and Katrin Paula. 2022. “The life, death and diversity of pro-government militias: The fully revised pro-government militias database version 2.0.” *Research & Politics* 9 (1): 20531680211062772.

Clifford, Scott, Geoffrey Sheagley, and Spencer Piston. 2021. “Increasing precision without altering treatment effects: Repeated measures designs in survey experiments.” *American Political Science Review* 115 (3): 1048–1065.

DiBlasi, Lora. 2020. “From shame to new name: how naming and shaming creates pro-government militias.” *International Studies Quarterly* 64 (4): 906–918.

Gelpi, Christopher, Jason Reifler, and Peter Feaver. 2007. “Iraq the vote: Retrospective and prospective foreign policy judgments on candidate choice and casualty tolerance.” *Political Behavior* 29:151–174.

Goldsmith, Benjamin E, Yusaku Horiuchi, and Kelly Matush. 2021. "Does public diplomacy sway foreign public opinion? Identifying the effect of high-level visits." *American Political Science Review* 115 (4): 1342–1357.

Gravelle, Timothy B, Jason Reifler, and Thomas J Scotto. 2017. "The Structure of Foreign Policy Attitudes in Transatlantic Perspective: Comparing the United States, United Kingdom, France and Germany." *European Journal of Political Research* 56 (4): 757–776.

———. 2021. "The Structure of Foreign Policy Attitudes Among Middle Power Publics: A Transpacific Replication." *Australian Journal of International Affairs* 75 (2): 217–236.

Hartig, Falk. 2016. "How China understands public diplomacy: The importance of national image for national interests." *International Studies Review* 18 (4): 655–680.

Heinrich, Tobias, Yoshiharu Kobayashi, and Leah Long. 2018. "Voters get what they want (when they pay attention): human rights, policy benefits, and foreign aid." *International Studies Quarterly* 62 (1): 195–207.

Holsti, Ole Rudolf. 2009. *Public opinion and American foreign policy.* University of Michigan Press.

Koren, Ore. 2017. "Means to an end: Pro-government militias as a predictive indicator of strategic mass killing." *Conflict Management and Peace Science* 34 (5): 461–484.

Malle, Bertram F, Steve Guglielmo, and Andrew E Monroe. 2014. "A theory of blame." *Psychological Inquiry* 25 (2): 147–186.

Marshall, Tyler, David Lamb, and John Goldman. 1999. "Indonesia Could Face Crippling Sanctions : Indonesia: U.S. suspends military ties with Asian nation over E. Timor turmoil." Los Angeles Times, September 10, 1999. Accessed October 5, 2024. https://www.latimes.com/archives/la-xpm-1999-sep-10-na-8610-story.html.

Mayhew, David R. 2004. *Congress: The Electoral Connection.* Yale University Press.

Milner, Helen V, and Dustin Tingley. 2015. *Sailing the water's edge: The domestic politics of American foreign policy.* Princeton University Press.

Mitchell, Neil J, Sabine C Carey, and Christopher K Butler. 2014. "The impact of pro-government militias on human rights violations." *International Interactions* 40 (5): 812–836.

Mitchell, Neil James. 2012. *Democracy's blameless leaders: From Dresden to Abu Ghraib, how leaders evade accountability for abuse, atrocity, and killing.* New York University Press.

NPR. 2011. "Ivory Coast Strongman Gbagbo Is Captured," April 11, 2011. Accessed February 27, 2025. https://www.npr.org/2011/04/11/135313388/ivory-coasts-former-strongman-is-captured.

Rathbun, Brian C, Joshua D Kertzer, Jason Reifler, Paul Goren, and Thomas J Scotto. 2016. "Taking foreign policy personally: Personal values and foreign policy attitudes." *International Studies Quarterly* 60 (1): 124–137.

Simmons, Beth A. 2009. *Mobilizing for human rights: international law in domestic politics.* Routledge.

Simpson, Brad, and Varsha Venkatasubramanian. 2019. "U.S. sought to preserve close ties to Indonesian military as it terrorized East Timor in runup to 1999 independence referendum." National Security Archive, George Washington University, August 28, 2019. Accessed November 7, 2025. https://nsarchive.gwu.edu/briefing-book/indonesia/2019-08-28/us-sought-preserve-close-ties-indonesian-military-it-terrorized-east-timor-runup-1999-independence.

Stagnaro, M.N., J.N. Druckman, A.J. Berinsky, A.A. Arechar, R. Willer, and D.G. Rand. 2024. "Representativeness Versus Attentiveness: A Comparison Across Nine Online Survey Samples." *PsyArXiv: Unpublished* 22:1–21.

Stanton, Jessica A. 2015. "Regulating Militias: Governments, Militias, and Civilian Targeting in Civil War." *The Journal of Conflict Resolution* 59 (5): 899–923.

Steinert, Christoph V, Janina I Steinert, and Sabine C Carey. 2019. "Spoilers of peace: Pro-government militias as risk factors for conflict recurrence." *Journal of Peace Research* 56 (2): 249–263.

Tomz, Michael, Jessica LP Weeks, and Keren Yarhi-Milo. 2020. "Public opinion and decisions about military force in democracies." *International Organization* 74 (1): 119–143.

Wang, Jay. 2006. "Public diplomacy and global business." *Journal of business Strategy* 27 (3): 41–49.

Wittkopf, Eugene R. 1990. *Faces of Internationalism: Public Opinion and American Foreign Policy.* Duke University Press.

A Regression Tables

Table 2: Regression results for H1 Plausible Deniability

	Dependent variable:		
	PD Index	Gov. Truth	Actor Rogue
	(1)	(2)	(3)
Semi-Official	-0.008	-0.183^{***}	0.169^{**}
	(0.066)	(0.067)	(0.069)
Informal	0.520^{***}	0.422^{***}	0.456^{***}
	(0.067)	(0.068)	(0.070)
Independent	0.809^{***}	0.662^{***}	0.705^{***}
	(0.067)	(0.068)	(0.069)
Constant	-1.518^{***}	-1.122^{***}	-1.445^{***}
	(0.415)	(0.420)	(0.432)
Observations	1,512	1,512	1,512
R^2	0.195	0.175	0.129
Adjusted R^2	0.182	0.161	0.115
Residual Std. Error (df = 1487)	0.904	0.916	0.941
F Statistic (df = 24; 1487)	15.029^{***}	13.122^{***}	9.157^{***}

Note: *p<0.1; **p<0.05; ***p<0.01
All models include the same set of controls.
All dependent variables are standardized to facilitate comparison.
Analytical standard errors.

Table 3: Regression results for H2 Blame

	Dependent variable:			
	Gov. Blame	Causation	Intention	Cap. to Prevent
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)
Semi-Official	−0.009	0.008	0.074	0.060
	(0.168)	(0.099)	(0.107)	(0.082)
Informal	−1.955***	−0.990***	−0.982***	−0.490***
	(0.169)	(0.099)	(0.108)	(0.082)
Independent	−2.517***	−1.425***	−1.495***	−0.722***
	(0.169)	(0.099)	(0.108)	(0.082)
Post-Denial	−0.695***	−0.207***	−0.188***	−0.143***
	(0.081)	(0.047)	(0.048)	(0.043)
Post-Denial×Semi-Official	−0.063	0.004	−0.093	0.035
	(0.114)	(0.066)	(0.068)	(0.061)
Post-Denial×Informal	−0.010	−0.023	−0.007	−0.010
	(0.114)	(0.066)	(0.068)	(0.061)
Post-Denial×Independent	0.192*	0.063	0.167**	−0.008
	(0.114)	(0.066)	(0.068)	(0.061)
Constant	8.244***	7.064***	6.334***	5.596***
	(0.988)	(0.582)	(0.636)	(0.475)
Observations	3,024	3,024	3,024	3,024
Log Likelihood	−6,150.165	−4,542.851	−4,710.847	−4,123.289
Akaike Inf. Crit.	12,362.330	9,147.702	9,483.695	8,308.578
Bayesian Inf. Crit.	12,548.770	9,334.147	9,670.139	8,495.023

Note: *p<0.1; **p<0.05; ***p<0.01
All models include participant-random-effects and the same set of controls.
Analytical standard errors.

Table 4: Regression results for H3 Punishment: Mean-Standardized Punishment Measures

	Dependent variable:					
	Favorability	Punishment Index	Assistance	Good Standing	Investigate	Sanction
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)	(6)
Semi-Official	-0.514^{***}	0.048	-0.153^{**}	-0.036	-0.042	0.017
	(0.166)	(0.060)	(0.069)	(0.067)	(0.051)	(0.061)
Informal	1.059^{***}	-0.398^{***}	0.232^{***}	0.403^{***}	-0.289^{***}	-0.419^{***}
	(0.167)	(0.060)	(0.070)	(0.067)	(0.052)	(0.061)
Independent	1.712^{***}	-0.579^{***}	0.414^{***}	0.588^{***}	-0.420^{***}	-0.514^{***}
	(0.167)	(0.060)	(0.069)	(0.067)	(0.052)	(0.061)
Post-Denial	0.236^{***}	-0.032^{*}	0.022	0.043	0.003	-0.048^{*}
	(0.064)	(0.020)	(0.028)	(0.027)	(0.020)	(0.026)
Post-Denial×Semi-Official	0.177^{**}	-0.032	0.034	-0.017	-0.044	-0.044
	(0.090)	(0.028)	(0.039)	(0.038)	(0.029)	(0.037)
Post-Denial×Informal	-0.009	-0.058^{**}	0.028	0.026	-0.061^{**}	-0.074^{**}
	(0.090)	(0.028)	(0.039)	(0.038)	(0.029)	(0.037)
Post-Denial×Independent	-0.063	-0.031	0.010	0.028	-0.043	-0.020
	(0.090)	(0.028)	(0.039)	(0.038)	(0.029)	(0.037)
Constant	1.275	1.176^{***}	-0.959^{**}	-1.195^{***}	0.776^{***}	1.139^{***}
	(0.997)	(0.354)	(0.404)	(0.392)	(0.301)	(0.353)
Observations	3,024	3,024	3,024	3,024	3,024	3,024
Log Likelihood	−5,810.739	−2,518.334	−3,235.127	−3,149.484	−2,334.904	−2,939.997
Akaike Inf. Crit.	11,683.480	5,098.667	6,532.255	6,360.968	4,731.808	5,941.994
Bayesian Inf. Crit.	11,869.920	5,285.112	6,718.699	6,547.413	4,918.252	6,128.438

Note: $^{*}p<0.1$; $^{**}p<0.05$; $^{***}p<0.01$

Each model includes the pre-treatment outcome measure as a control.

All models include participant-random-effects and the same demographic controls.

Analytical standard errors.

Table 5: Regression results for H3 Punishment: Non-Standardized Punishment Measures

	Dependent variable:				
	Punishment Index	Assistance	Good Standing	Investigate	Sanction
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)
Semi-Official	0.070	-0.245^{**}	-0.063	-0.080	0.029
	(0.087)	(0.111)	(0.117)	(0.098)	(0.108)
Informal	-0.582^{***}	0.372^{***}	0.701^{***}	-0.549^{***}	-0.747^{***}
	(0.088)	(0.112)	(0.117)	(0.098)	(0.109)
Independent	-0.846^{***}	0.663^{***}	1.022^{***}	-0.799^{***}	-0.916^{***}
	(0.088)	(0.111)	(0.117)	(0.098)	(0.109)
Post-Denial	-0.047^{*}	0.034	0.074	0.005	-0.085^{*}
	(0.029)	(0.044)	(0.047)	(0.039)	(0.046)
Post-Denial×Semi-Official	-0.047	0.055	-0.030	-0.084	-0.078
	(0.040)	(0.062)	(0.066)	(0.055)	(0.065)
Post-Denial×Informal	-0.084^{**}	0.045	0.044	-0.116^{**}	-0.131^{**}
	(0.040)	(0.062)	(0.066)	(0.055)	(0.065)
Post-Denial×Independent	-0.045	0.016	0.048	-0.082	-0.035
	(0.040)	(0.062)	(0.066)	(0.055)	(0.065)
Constant	5.208^{***}	1.337^{**}	1.307^{*}	5.474^{***}	5.123^{***}
	(0.528)	(0.663)	(0.717)	(0.578)	(0.634)
Observations	3,024	3,024	3,024	3,024	3,024
Log Likelihood	−3,657.113	−4,647.186	−4,808.461	−4,260.899	−4,673.839
Akaike Inf. Crit.	7,376.226	9,356.373	9,678.923	8,583.797	9,409.678
Bayesian Inf. Crit.	7,562.670	9,542.817	9,865.367	8,770.242	9,596.123

Note: *p<0.1; **p<0.05; ***p<0.01
Each model includes the pre-treatment outcome measure as a control.
All models include participant-random-effects and the same demographic controls.
Analytical standard errors.

B Previous Survey

I have previously attempted this project with a different survey experiment. The OSF pre-registration for this previous project can be found here: https://osf.io/5ucmx/overview?view_only=1d730638890542c5adf7e62aad167cc3. The previous experiment featured various design flaws and details that likely systematically influenced responses and complicated my ability to cleanly estimate the effect of delegating violence on public perceptions.

In the previous 2×2 design, I presented respondents with a similar vignette in which either the military or a PGM committed violence—the "actor" treatment—and then information from a debate in Congress suggests whether the foreign government was or was not responsible for the violence—the "information" treatment. This resulted in the following four treatment conditions: *military-responsible*, *military-not-responsible*, *PGM-responsible*, and *PGM-not-responsible*. Both treatments were included in one vignette, and thus administered simultaneously. This survey structure created three key problems: competing and contradictory treatments, a treated control condition, and a latent, third treatment.

First, in abstract terms, the "actor" and "information" treatment were both informational treatments, telling the survey respondent who committed violence and additional information about the government's control over the actor. In this sense, my results reflected the comparative persuasiveness of two competing pieces of information, rather than isolating the independent effect of delegation or auxiliary information on subsequent deniability. The actor and its connection to the government are inextricably linked pieces of information. This treatment arrangement also resulted in a strange experimental condition in which the military committed violence, but auxiliary information suggested that the government couldn't control the military. Given the potentially contradictory nature of these treatments, theoretically interpreting the results from this condition posed serious challenges.

Second, I envisioned that the *military-responsible* condition could serve as the control condition since the military is the theoretical alternative for states that would delegate to PGMs. However, given that both treatments were applied simultaneously, even this control condition received an informational treatment. Thus, I had to interpret all “effects” with reference to this *military-responsible* condition, rather than being able to estimate a true treatment effect.

Finally, across all conditions respondents read about an instance of violence, receiving a latent, “demonstrated violence” treatment. The mere presence of violence in a country may heuristically influence respondents’ perceptions, regardless of the actor committing the violence. The previous survey design prevented me from empirically distinguishing the effect of demonstrated violence from the effect of delegation or information.

The previous survey also featured various contextual details and emphases that likely systematically influenced respondent’s reactions. First, rather than using a hypothetical country, the previous survey randomized between four African countries. Other survey experimental research has demonstrated that racial stereotypes have a major influence on US respondent’s perceptions and preferences over interaction (Baker 2015). Furthermore, the previous survey’s outcome questions heavily focused on the provision of foreign aid, following Carey et al. (2015) empirical operationalization of a state’s sensitivity to punishment. The combination of the African context and then querying support for foreign aid created severe ceiling effects in which an overwhelming majority of respondents across all treatment conditions strongly opposed continued foreign aid provision.

The current survey design overcomes each of these problems, providing a cleaner test of the implications of plausible deniability theory. First, the treatment design reflects a better understanding of “information,” combining actor and auxiliary information into treatment conditions that are both theoretically relevant and empirically common. Furthermore, by improving the treatment design, I am able to use the *military* condition as the baseline since there are no competing treatments applied to this condition.[8] These design improvements

8. As discussed in the main manuscript, I do not use a “no-actor-specified” condition since it would create further problems interpreting results. Violence does not simply occur—an actor must commit it. If I failed to specify an actor, respondents would infer one. But in this case, I could not control for these inferences. Thus, specifying the military makes sense since this is the theoretically relevant alternative agent for abusive violence.

significantly improve the internal and external validity of this design over the previous one.

Additionally, the current design leverages repeated measures, collecting responses at multiple stages in the survey. Importantly, I ask respondents to report their favorability for the foreign government before any violence occurs, enabling me to better isolate the effect of demonstrated violence from the actor treatment. Finally, I changed the vignette setting to a hypothetical country to avoid systematically inducing any racial biases in the responses. I also expanded outcome questions beyond the narrower focus on foreign aid to ensure that aversion to aid, specifically, does not bias my results.

C Survey:

Pre-Treatment Phase

Demographics, Partisanship

1. What is your age?
2. What is your gender?
3. What is your race?
4. In what state do you live?
5. What is the highest level of school you have completed or the highest degree you have received?
6. Generally speaking, do you usually think of yourself as a Democrat, an Independent, or a Republican?
7. (*If Independent*, do you lean toward one party or another? *–Assign to party if respondent selects a party*)

Foreign Policy Orientation

7-point, agree/ disagree scale.
Questions presented in random order.

8. Rather than simply countering our opponents thrusts, it is necessary to strike at the heart of an opponents power.
9. The United States must demonstrate its resolve so that others do not take advantage of it.
10. The United States should always do what is in its own interest, even if our allies object.
11. The United States should take all steps including the use of force to prevent aggression by any expansionist power.
12. The United States needs to cooperate more with the United Nations.
13. The United States should contribute forces to international peace-keeping efforts.
14. The use or threat of force sometimes creates more problems than it solves by creating hostility or fear on the part of the opposing side.
15. In deciding on its foreign policies, the U.S. should take into account the views of its major allies.

16. The U.S. should mind its own business internationally and let other countries get along the best they can on their own.

17. We should not think so much in international terms but concentrate more on our own national problems and building up our strength and prosperity here at home.

Attention Check

This question presented randomly within the FP Orientation battery.

18. Agree/Disagree: In thinking about international affairs, it is important that individuals pay close attention by selecting "somewhat disagree" for this statement.

Case Introduction: Centralia

Centralia is a hypothetical country. Centralia is composed of two major ethnic groups—Northerners and Southerners. Both groups are native to the region and speak the same language, but have different religions and cultural customs. For many years, Northerners and Southerners fought over access to resources. After an intense civil war in the 1990s, the sides settled their differences and, with US assistance, formed a stable unified government.

The current President of Centralia was elected in 2015 by an overwhelming majority of Southerners. The president has claimed to serve all citizens despite lacking political support in the North. Since coming into office in 2015, the President of Centralia has helped develop the country's economy and increase living standards for both Southerners and Northerners. Centralia has widely been hailed as a success story for countries struggling to overcome historical ethnic differences.

Pre-Treatment Outcomes:

H3 Punishment, First Collection

19. On a scale from 0 to 10, where 0 means very unfavorable, 10 means very favorable, and 5 means neutral, how do you feel about the government of Centralia?

20. Please indicate your level of agreement or disagreement with the following statements:

    - Centralia should remain a candidate for assistance and aid from international organizations like the World Bank.
    - Centralia should remain in good standing within international organizations like the UN.
    - Countries should put sanctions on the government of Centralia.
    - The UN should investigate the government of Centralia.

Delegation Phase: Actor Information

Reports have recently emerged from Centralia's northern regions describing a wave of brutal ethnic violence targeting northern communities over the past week. Eyewitness accounts detail numerous atrocities. Northerners were rounded up and arbitrarily detained with many being beaten and tortured during interrogations. In some cases, Northerners were publicly executed in the town square, and entire villages were burned to the ground, leaving communities paralyzed by fear. Observers estimate that upwards of 100 northerners have been killed during the violent campaign.

INDEPENDENT ETHNIC ARMED GROUP

The attacks were allegedly carried out by members of a southern ethnic armed group. The group claims to provide security for ethnic southerners living in the north.

INFORMAL PGM

The attacks were allegedly carried out by members of a southern ethnic armed group. The group claims to provide security for ethnic southerners living in the north.

The armed group openly supports the government, and political opponents have accused the government of providing weapons and financial support to this group. The government has consistently denied this accusation, however.

SEMI-OFFICIAL PGM

The attacks were allegedly carried out by members of a southern ethnic armed group. The group claims to provide security for ethnic southerners living in the north.

The armed group openly supports the government, and the government provides weapons and financial support to the group. The government has legally authorized the group to operate; however, the group is not part of the official military.

OFFICIAL MILITARY

The attacks were allegedly carried out by members of the Centralian military. The military has been providing security in communities across the north.

Delegation Phase Outcomes

H2 Blame, First Collection

21. To what extent do you believe that the government of Centralia is to blame for these violent attacks?

    Rate your level of agreement/ disagreement with the following statements:

22. **Causality:** The government caused the violence, either directly or indirectly.

23. **Intention:** The government intended for this violence to occur.

24. **Capacity:** The government could have done something to prevent or stop the violence.

H3 Punishment, Second Collection

25. On a scale from 0 to 10, where 0 means very unfavorable, 10 means very favorable, and 5 means neutral, how do you feel about the government of Centralia?

26. Please indicate your level of agreement or disagreement with the following statements:

    - Centralia should remain a candidate for assistance and aid from international organizations like the World Bank.
    - Centralia should remain in good standing within international organizations like the UN.
    - Countries should put sanctions on the government of Centralia.
    - The UN should investigate the government of Centralia.

Denial Phase

In a press conference, the president of Centralia firmly denied any involvement in the violence. "The government of Centralia is committed to the safety and well-being of all its citizens, regardless of ethnicity," the president stated. "Those responsible for these acts do not represent the government or its interests." No further comments were provided.

Denial Phase Outcomes

H1 Denial Plausibility

27. Do you think the president of Centralia is telling the truth when he denies involvement in the violence?

    - Definitely telling the truth
    - Probably telling the truth
    - Don't Know/ Unsure
    - Probably not telling the truth
    - Definitely not telling the truth

28. How possible is it that the [Actor] acted independently, without direction or coordination from the government?

    - Very Possible
    - Somewhat Possible
    - Don't Know/ Unsure
    - Not Very Possible
    - Not At All Possible

H2 Blame, Second Collection

29. To what extent do you believe that the government of Centralia is to blame for these violent attacks?

    Rate your level of agreement/ disagreement with the following statements:

30. **Causality:** The government caused the violence, either directly or indirectly.

31. **Intention:** The government intended for this violence to occur.

32. **Capacity:** The government could have done something to prevent or stop the violence.

H3 Punishment, Third Collection

33. On a scale from 0 to 10, where 0 means very unfavorable, 10 means very favorable, and 5 means neutral, how do you feel about the government of Centralia?

34. Please indicate your level of agreement or disagreement with the following statements:

    - Centralia should remain a candidate for assistance and aid from international organizations like the World Bank.
    - Centralia should remain in good standing within international organizations like the UN.
    - Countries should put sanctions on the government of Centralia.
    - The UN should investigate the government of Centralia.